Episode 5 · Finale

The Sunken Sanctuary

ប្រាសាទលិចទឹក

Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Phnom Kulen and its hidden temple catacombs, Siem Reap Province
In-story time	3:00 AM – sunrise (about 6:00 AM)
Playtime	3.5 – 4.5 hours
Seal	#5 · The Golden Inscription Slab
Version	2.0 · October 2026 · Draft for review

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01 Episode Overview

The fused blood line leads Sora to Phnom Kulen, the sacred mountain. Behind a waterfall lies a sunken temple where the Neak Ta keeps the original contract. Everything she has learned is tested in four elemental trials before she faces the guardian itself and performs the ritual that will either free her family or bind her forever.

LOCATION **Phnom Kulen** Waterfall cave and catacombs	TIME **3:00 AM – dawn** The final night	PLAYTIME **3.5 – 4.5 hours** 3 acts + endings
CORE MECHANIC **Trials and ritual** Hub, four trials, boss ritual	ENTITY **Neak Ta Guardian** Fully manifested	SEAL **#5 Golden Inscription Slab** The original contract

1.1 Episode goal

Place the four cleansed seal remnants on their elemental shrines, open the Sanctum of the Banyan Tree, and complete the **Ritual of Severance** on the Golden Inscription Slab to end the ancestral debt.

1.2 Role in the series

Introduces	A hub with trials playable in any order, the chant choice interface, a three-phase boss ritual and the ending resolver.
Reuses	Every earlier skill: watched/unwatched (Episode 1), mirror beams (Episode 2), sound stealth (Episode 2), resource timing (Episode 1), and the white thread and incense rituals.
Concludes	The story of the debt, with two endings decided by the player's actions across all five episodes.

1.3 Visual identity

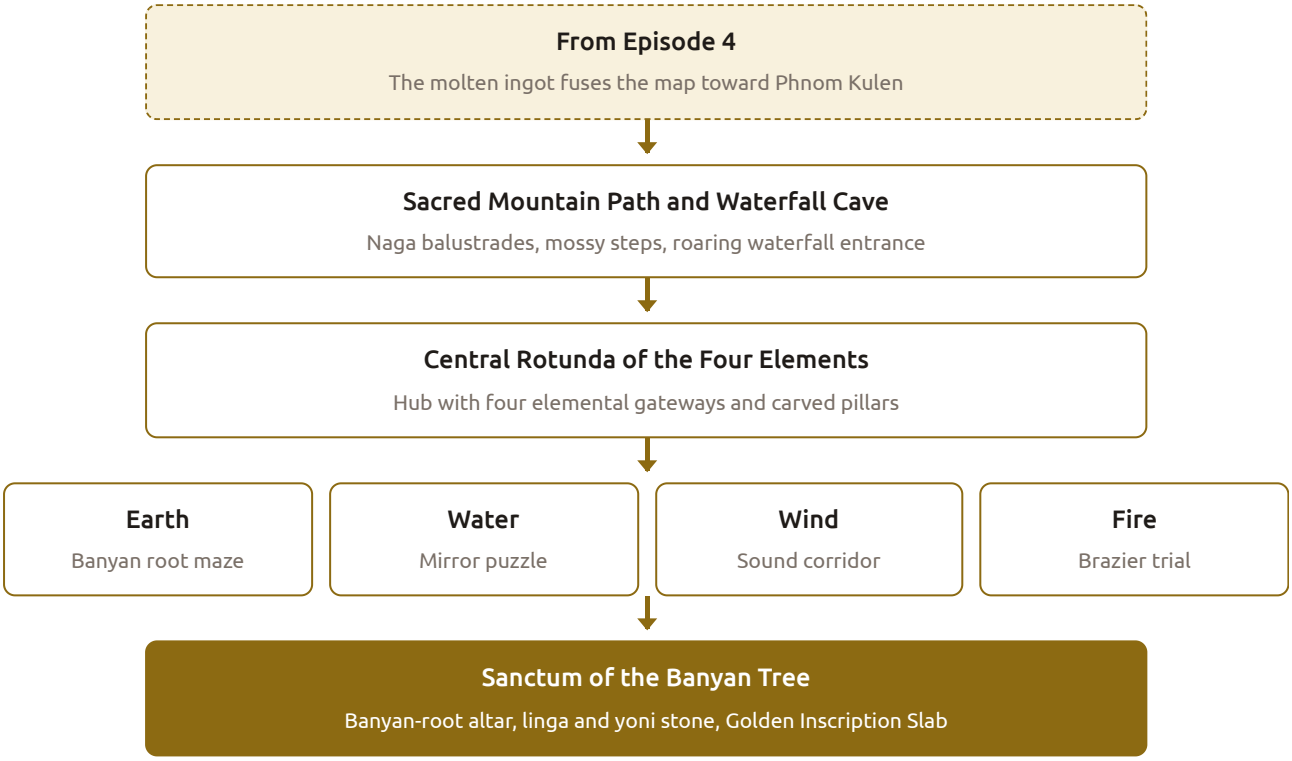
Ancient mossy sandstone, glowing spirit amber, deep jungle green, golden runes that glow on their own, drifting mist, and a dramatic final change to warm golden morning light.

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora ស៊ូរ៉ា	Protagonist	Exhausted and battle-tested, carrying the weight of four generations of family history. She brings together everything she has learned: stealth, sound, spatial awareness and ritual knowledge.	Player character.
The Neak Ta Guardian អ្នកតា	Final antagonist	The land guardian fully manifested: a towering multi-armed silhouette of shadow and ancient stone, wearing a glowing, distorted brass mask. It rules the catacombs and bends space and light to protect its contract.	Boss of the severance ritual.
Ancestral voices Uncle Sok and the great-grandfather	Guides and testers	Echoing memories that guide or test Sora through choices inside the trial chambers.	Story choices; hints.

03 Locations and Layout

3.1 Progression map



3.2 Area details

Area	Description and key props	Gameplay use
Mountain Approach and Waterfall	A steep sandstone staircase carved into the jungle cliffside, flanked by moss-covered seven-headed Naga balustrades. A roaring waterfall hides the catacomb entrance. Fallen carvings, Khmer boundary stones (ស៊ីមា), flickering stone oil braziers, overgrown banyan roots.	Ascent; arrival; mood
Central Rotunda	A massive circular underground chamber of carved sandstone blocks. In the centre, a stone relief map of Cambodia and an altar with four empty niches. Four monumental archways lead to the trials.	Hub; seal-remnant placement
Earth · Chamber of Roots	A labyrinth of huge banyan roots (ព្រៃ) bursting through the stone walls, forming shifting maze paths.	Sight trial
Water · Chamber of Reflections	Submerged stone basins fed by mountain springs, lined with Apsara (អប្សរា) carvings that reflect light off the water.	Light-reflection trial

Area	Description and key props	Gameplay use
Wind · Chamber of Whispers	A narrow carved corridor lined with ancient Pali inscriptions, where heavy gusts howl through stone lattice windows.	Sound and timing trial
Fire · Chamber of Flames	A hot chamber lit by rows of ancient iron oil braziers and stone incense altars.	Resource and timing trial
Sanctum of the Banyan Tree	A towering circular sanctum whose open dome shows the night sky. At its centre, an ancient banyan's roots wrap around a sacred linga and yoni altar holding the Golden Inscription Slab.	Boss ritual; endings

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Act I · The Mountain Path and the Four Gateways

Playtime 0:00 – 1:00 · Story 3:00 – 3:45 AM

NARRATIVE

At **3:00 AM**, Sora reaches Phnom Kulen (ភ្នំគូលែន). Guided by her sketchbook and the molten ingot, she climbs the ancient Naga staircase through tropical mist and enters a hidden cave behind a roaring waterfall.

Inside lies the Central Rotunda of the Four Elements. A stone altar shows four empty niches, one for each seal she broke in Episodes 1–4. To open the way to the Final Sanctum, she must enter the four elemental chambers and place each cleansed seal remnant on its matching shrine.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Hub navigation	The four trials can be played in any order from the rotunda.
Placing the remnants	Sora takes each cleansed remnant from her satchel (Bronze Token fragment, Silver Betel Box inlay, Terracotta Jar soil, molten iron ingot) and places it on its elemental altar.

Act II · The Four Elemental Trials

Playtime 1:00 – 2:30 · Story 3:45 – 4:45 AM

Each chamber tests one of the core skills Sora has mastered on her journey.

Trial	Skill tested	Challenge	Origin
Earth	Sight and line of sight	Cross a maze of banyan roots where stone statues move only when Sora looks away. Use the lamp shutter and careful camera control to freeze them and clear the path.	Episode 1 (the corpse)
Water	Light reflection	Rotate polished bronze mirrors across the basins to aim a moonbeam at three crystal gems in an Apsara relief, draining the central basin.	Episode 2 (library mirrors)
Wind	Sound stealth and timing	Cross a narrow stone bridge over a chasm. Gusts mask footsteps; when the wind stops, Pret listen from the shadows. Move only while the wind howls and stand completely still when it falls silent.	Episode 2 (Pret)

Trial	Skill tested	Challenge	Origin
Fire	Resource management and timing	Light a series of stone braziers in a precise geometric order using the remaining matches and lamp oil, while dodging moving fire traps.	Episode 1 (incense, matches)

Act III · The Ritual of Severance

Playtime 2:30 – 4:00 · Story 4:45 AM – sunrise

NARRATIVE

With all four shrines active, the heavy stone doors of the rotunda slide open to reveal the Sanctum of the Banyan Tree.

At its centre lies the **Golden Inscription Slab**, the fifth and final seal, bearing the original blood contract of 1910. As Sora approaches, the ground trembles and the Neak Ta Guardian manifests in its full, terrifying form: a multi-armed being of shadow and ancient stone, towering over the altar.

Sora cannot fight it. She must complete the Ritual of Severance while evading its attacks (see section 5).

05 The Ritual of Severance (Boss Sequence)

The ritual has three phases. Throughout, the Guardian attacks the area with sweeping blows and reaches for Sora with shadow tendrils. Each phase starts from its own checkpoint.

Phase	Player actions	Pressure and failure
1 · The Four Corners	Run to the four corner pillars of the sanctum, tie blessed white cotton thread around each, and light sanctified incense at each.	Area attacks and tendrils between pillars. Being hit costs time and causes shadow damage.
2 · The Chants	At the central altar, recite the counter-mantras by choosing lines that match the funeral chants (สฺวฺคิ) recorded in the sketchbook.	Each wrong choice causes shadow damage and is counted toward the ending.
3 · The Blood Offering	Prick a finger with a brass pin and place a drop of blood on the Golden Inscription Slab to formally nullify the ancestral debt.	Final, uninterrupted moment; the outcome depends on the ending conditions.

> **SHADOW DAMAGE**
>
> There is no health bar. Damage is shown by the screen darkening, sound distortion and Sora's breathing. After two or three hits (*target*) Sora is overwhelmed and the phase restarts from its checkpoint.

06 Endings

TRUE ENDING · THE UNBROKEN FREEDOM

Conditions: the player kept the cultural taboos, collected all hidden lore notes, and completed the ritual chants without error.

Resolution: As Sora places her blood on the slab and recites the final chant, a blinding golden light bursts from the banyan tree. The Neak Ta lowers its hands, bows its masked head in respect and dissolves into glowing dust. Above the open dome, the night sky turns into a golden sunrise. Sora walks out of the catacombs into the morning sun, free from the past. Back in Battambang, Uncle Sok's cremation fire burns peacefully under a clear sky as her family finds peace.

BAD ENDING · BOUND TO THE SOIL

Conditions: the player made major errors in the chants or failed key lore choices during the series.

Resolution: Sora completes the ritual, but the counter-mantra is incomplete. The Neak Ta rejects the severance and declares the debt unpaid. Darkness swallows the sanctum. Sora wakes inside the wooden coffin at the Battambang stilt house from Episode 1, trapped forever in the spirit world, while her family mourns over her lifeless body in the world of the living.

6.1 Ending conditions

These counters must be tracked from Episode 1 onward and saved between episodes.

Counter	Examples of sources	True ending requires
Taboos broken	Wasting rice offerings (Ep 2), answering or turning to a mimic (Ep 4), neglecting the vigil duties (Ep 1)	None, or below a set limit
Hidden lore notes found	Optional letters, photographs and records in every episode	All
Chant errors	Wrong choices in Phase 2	None
Key lore choices	Story choices across Episodes 1–4 (to be defined)	The "right" choices (to be defined)

07 Mechanics Reference

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback to the player
Hub and trials	Four trials playable in any order. Completing a trial lights its shrine; four lit shrines open the sanctum.	Glowing runes on the rotunda altar.
Remnant placement	Each remnant fits one elemental altar. Placement is done physically from the satchel.	Remnant settles into its niche with light and sound.
Moving statues	Statues move only when out of view or in darkness. Lamp light and direct view freeze them.	Grinding stone when the player looks away.
Wind timing	Movement is safe only during gusts. Moving during silence alerts the Pret.	Wind volume; lattice whistling.
Brazier order	Braziers must be lit in a geometric order shown in the sketchbook. Wrong order resets the sequence; each attempt costs matches and oil.	Flames flare or die.
Chant choices	Lines are presented as choices in the sketchbook. The player picks the line matching the recorded chant.	Correct lines glow; wrong lines bring shadow damage.

08 Items and Collectibles

Item	Type	Use
Bronze Token fragment	Remnant	From Episode 1. Placed on its elemental shrine.
Silver Betel Box inlay	Remnant	From Episode 2. Placed on its elemental shrine.
Terracotta Jar soil	Remnant	From Episode 3. Placed on its elemental shrine.
Molten iron ingot	Remnant	From Episode 4. Guides the way; placed on its elemental shrine.
Blessed white cotton thread	Ritual item	From Episode 2. Tied around the four pillars.
Sanctified incense, matches, lamp oil	Consumables	Fire trial and Phase 1.
Brass pin	Ritual item	Phase 3 blood offering.
Golden Inscription Slab	Seal #5	The original contract; target of the ritual.

09 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Ancient sandstone grey, moss green, glowing rune gold, amber, deep navy turning to golden dawn.
Post-processing	Strong bloom, light shafts through the open dome, screen distortion during boss attacks, film grain.
Light sources	Oil lantern, glowing golden runes, stone braziers, moonlight turning to sunlight.
Ambience	Deep underground bass, wind through stone lattices, dripping water, slow and ominous Pinpeat (ពិណពាទ្យ) roneat phrases.
Horror sound cues	Sliding stone blocks, the Neak Ta's layered echoing voice, roaring wind, shattering glass, ritual chanting.
Interface	100% diegetic. Inventory, chants and puzzle solutions are tracked only in Sora's sketchbook.

10 Glossary

Term (v1)	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Phnom Kulen	ភ្នំគូលេន	Sacred mountain north of Angkor	
Sima	សីមា	Sacred boundary stone	
Sprean	ជ្រៃ	Banyan tree	v1 term unclear; "chrey" suggested
Apsara	អប្សរា	Celestial dancer	
Linga / Yoni	លិង្គ / យោនី	Shaivite sacred stones	Treat respectfully; still venerated
Smat	ស្មូត	Buddhist funeral chanting	Usually romanised "smot"
Mukhalingi	មុខលិង្គ	—	"Mukhalinga" is a linga carved with a face, not a mask; rename the Guardian's mask
Pinpeat / Roneat	ពិណពាទ្យ / រនាត	Classical ensemble / xylophone	

11 Revision Notes and Open Issues

Changes from v1.0

- Reorganised into the standard episode structure; separated the boss sequence and endings into their own sections; added ending-condition tracking, mechanics, item and glossary sections.
- Defined shadow damage (no health bar; two or three hits restart the phase).
- Khmer text now renders correctly.

Open issues

DECIDE BEFORE BUILDING EPISODE 5

- **"Four artifacts she destroyed":** the Silver Betel Box is never destroyed or cleansed in Episode 2. Add that ritual to Episode 2 so the "inlay" remnant exists.
- **"Key lore choices"** are not defined in any earlier episode. Design one or two meaningful choices per episode, or remove this condition.
- **Which remnant belongs to which element** (for example earth = token, water = jar soil, fire = ingot, wind = betel box inlay).
- **Pret in the Wind trial:** explain in the sketchbook why they appear here.
- **The blood offering** and the linga/yoni altar are sensitive; review with the cultural advisor and keep the presentation restrained.
- **The Guardian's mask name** ("Mukhalingi") needs replacing with an accurate term.